

Legal Counsel

FF17 Legal, policy and public administration · ISCO-08 2619 · CBS 0621 Juristen · seniority medior · Also known as: Corporate Counsel, Legal Specialist

Analyses legal issues, independently drafts contracts and opinions and represents the organisation in legal proceedings and negotiations.

The legal counsel advises line management and the board on legal risk and drafts contracts and legal documents independently. Unlike the legal officer, they carry final responsibility for the legal quality of their advice. In practice selection fails on candidates who are strong on legal knowledge but do not translate advice into a usable decision for a non-legal audience.

Key figures for this profile

25 skills · 6 competencies to measure · 5 knockout skills · centre of gravity: Communication and influence 23%, Professional knowledge domains 22%, Cognitive ability and problem solving 18%

1 Competencies to measure

These are the behavioural and ability constructs in this profile. Each one shows which hrmforce questionnaire measures it.

Competencies to measure	Target level	hrmforce instrument	Assessment method	Behavioural anchor at target level
integrity and dependability Competency (50-framework): Integriteit Knockout	 N4	Big Fifty (schaal Integriteit), 360 Feedback, Structureerd interview	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Reports a possible conflict of interest on own initiative and asks for review before a decision is taken.

Competencies to measure	Target level	hrmforce instrument	Assessment method	Behavioural anchor at target level
Verbal reasoning	 N4	Ability Scan	Cognitieve capaciteitentest	Extracts the core arguments from a report of several pages and shows with textual references which conclusion does and does not follow.
Judgement under uncertainty Competency (50-framework): Oordeelsvorming	 N3	Big Fifty, Competency Check	Situational Judgement Test	Forms a judgement on incomplete files, names the assumptions used and states which new fact would change that judgement.
organisational awareness Competency (50-framework): Organisatiesensitiviteit	 N3	Big Fifty, Competency Check, 360 Feedback	Situational Judgement Test	Assesses which interests a proposal touches, involves the right people beforehand and chooses a suitable moment to raise it.
independence Competency (50-framework): Onafhankelijkheid	 N3	Big Fifty, 15PF	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Takes a decision that departs from the group line, explains the reasoning behind it and accepts the consequences.

Competencies to measure	Target level	hrmforce instrument	Assessment method	Behavioural anchor at target level
Stress tolerance Competency (50-framework): Stressbestendigheid		Big Fifty, 15PF, Mentale Weerbaarheid (4C)	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Keeps working in a structured way at peak load, keeps agreements with clients clear and flags early which results are at risk.

2 Full skill profile

Every skill in this profile, sorted by weight. The behavioural anchor under each skill belongs to the target level.

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	Legal analysis Determines the organisation's legal line on matters of principle and shares knowledge of the field of law with the profession.	 N5	5	yes	Werkproef	Kennistoets (klantspecifiek), Werkproef
V	Critical thinking and source evaluation Detects fallacies and selective evidence in reports and states which conclusion the data do support.	 N4	5	yes	Werkproef	Competency Check, Werkproef
V	Business reporting Builds a report from question to conclusion, separates fact from interpretation and phrases recommendations with a named owner.	 N4	5	yes	Werkproef	Werkproef, Competency Check
V	Advisory skill Reframes the question behind the question, offers two supported options with consequences and agrees a decision moment.	 N4	5	yes	Assessment center	Competency Check, Structureerd interview

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
G	integrity and dependability Reports a possible conflict of interest on own initiative and asks for review before a decision is taken.	 N4	5	yes	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Big Fifty (schaal Integriteit), 360 Feedback, Structureerd interview
K	Applying legislation Independently assesses an application with exceptional circumstances, weighs discretionary room and motivates the decision traceably.	 N3	5	no	Kennistoets	Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)
A	Verbal reasoning Extracts the core arguments from a report of several pages and shows with textual references which conclusion does and does not follow.	 N4	4	no	Cognitieve capaciteitentest	Ability Scan
G	Judgement under uncertainty Forms a judgement on incomplete files, names the assumptions used and states which new fact would change that judgement.	 N3	4	no	Situational Judgement Test	Big Fifty, Competency Check

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	Stakeholder management Assesses influence and interest per party, chooses a fitting form of contact and discusses conflicting wishes before a decision is taken.	 N3	4	no	Assessment center	Competency Check, 360 Feedback
G	organisational awareness Assesses which interests a proposal touches, involves the right people beforehand and chooses a suitable moment to raise it.	 N3	4	no	Situational Judgement Test	Big Fifty, Competency Check, 360 Feedback
V	Policy development Independently elaborates a policy proposal with options and expected effects and organises consultation of the parties involved.	 N3	4	no	Portfolio/bewijsstuk	Portfolio, Competency Check
V	Systems thinking Maps the chain around a bottleneck, points out the feedback loop and predicts the effect of an intervention.	 N3	3	no	Werkproef	Competency Check, Werkproef
V	Editing and plain language Rewrites a formal letter to plain language level B1 and explains to the author which choices were made.	 N3	3	no	Werkproef	Werkproef

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	Negotiating Prepares a range and a fallback option beforehand, trades points of unequal weight and closes with written confirmation.	 N3	3	no	Assessment center	Conflictstijlen, Competency Check
G	independence Takes a decision that departs from the group line, explains the reasoning behind it and accepts the consequences.	 N3	3	no	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Big Fifty, 15PF
V	Professional currency and specialist literature Tracks sources and guidelines structurally, weighs their quality and adapts the own working method to new insights.	 N3	3	no	Portfolio/bewijsstuk	Portfolio, Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)
V	Searching and evaluating digital information Combines search terms and filters across several sources, weighs source reliability and justifies the selection made.	 N3	3	no	Werkproef	Ability Scan, Werkproef
K	GDPR and privacy in practice Judges in own processes whether a legal basis exists, applies data minimisation and handles requests from data subjects correctly.	 N3	3	no	Kennistoets	Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	Contracting and closing Recognises buying signals, names the remaining objection and puts a signable proposal on the table within own authority.	 N3	3	no	Werkproef	Competency Check, Werkproef
K	Basic contract law knowledge Assesses contracts on liability, termination and payment and proposes amendments within the own mandate.	 N3	3	no	Kennistoets	Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)
K	Complying with sector regulation Translates changed regulation into the own work instructions and checks whether the records meet the requirements.	 N3	3	no	Kennistoets	Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)
V	Public governance decision making Independently prepares a decision with clear options, aligns with the departments involved and anticipates questions from the council.	 N3	3	no	Portfolio/bewijsstuk	Portfolio, Competency Check
G	Stress tolerance Keeps working in a structured way at peak load, keeps agreements with clients clear and flags early which results are at risk.	 N3	2	no	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Big Fifty, 15PF, Mentale Weerbaarheid (4C)

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	Handling objections and appeals Registers an objection, checks the deadlines and drafts the standard letters to interested parties.	 N2	2	no	Werkproef	Werkproef, Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)
V	Planning own work Builds an own plan with milestones and dependencies, checks progress weekly and revises the plan when actual progress deviates.	 N3	1	no	Werkproef	Competency Check, 360 Feedback

3 Levels per seniority

The same profile with the job family seniority adjustment applied. Target levels are clamped to 1 to 5.

Skill	medior	senior
Legal analysis	N5	N5
Critical thinking and source evaluation	N4	N5
Business reporting	N4	N5
Advisory skill	N4	N4
integrity and dependability	N4	N5
Applying legislation	N3	N4
Verbal reasoning	N4	N5
Judgement under uncertainty	N3	N4
Stakeholder management	N3	N4
organisational awareness	N3	N4
Policy development	N3	N4
Systems thinking	N3	N4
Editing and plain language	N3	N4
Negotiating	N3	N4
independence	N3	N4
Professional currency and specialist literature	N3	N4
Searching and evaluating digital information	N3	N4
GDPR and privacy in practice	N3	N4
Contracting and closing	N3	N4
Basic contract law knowledge	N3	N4
Complying with sector regulation	N3	N4
Public governance decision making	N3	N4
Stress tolerance	N3	N4
Handling objections and appeals	N2	N3
Planning own work	N3	N4

4 The proficiency scale

Level	Label	Autonomy	Complexity	Scope	Depth of knowledge
N1	Guided	works under supervision and follows instruction	routine, one variable at a time	own task	basic understanding of terminology
N2	Applying	works independently within set frameworks	familiar situations with limited variation	own role	working knowledge, applies standard approach
N3	Proficient	sets own approach and seeks input proactively	several variables, some ambiguity	own team or process	thorough knowledge, weighs alternatives
N4	Advanced	directs others and decides on the approach	complex, with conflicting interests	several teams or a department	in-depth knowledge, advises others
N5	Leading	sets the standard and the policy	strategic, under high uncertainty	organisation, value chain or profession	authority, advances the profession

5 Behavioural anchors per skill

Anchors sit at N1, N3 and N5. N2 and N4 are deliberately not anchored: raters interpolate between them, following the O*NET convention.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
Legal analysis Reduces a case to the legally relevant facts, looks up the applicable rules and case law and arrives at a substantiated position.	Looks up the applicable statutory article for a simple question and summarises its content in own words.	Independently analyses a case with conflicting interests, weighs the case law and advises in writing on the line to take.	Determines the organisation's legal line on matters of principle and shares knowledge of the field of law with the profession.
Critical thinking and source evaluation Tests claims for logic, evidence and the interest of the source and thereby distinguishes facts from opinions and assumptions.	Asks what a claim is based on and checks whether the source is named and can be found.	Detects fallacies and selective evidence in reports and states which conclusion the data do support.	Sets the assessment criteria for sources and claims, including for texts made by artificial intelligence, and enforces them organisation wide.
Business reporting Bringing findings, figures and recommendations together in a report that leads the reader to a decision or next step in one reading.	Fills in an existing report template with the correct figures and describes per section what has been done.	Builds a report from question to conclusion, separates fact from interpretation and phrases recommendations with a named owner.	Sets the reporting line for the whole organisation, tests the quality of steering information and accounts for outcomes to board and regulator.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
Advisory skill Sharpening the question of a client and delivering a well founded recommendation in a way that the receiver adopts and implements it.	Supplies requested information and explains a standard recommendation following the fixed structure used by the team.	Reframes the question behind the question, offers two supported options with consequences and agrees a decision moment.	Advises the board on issues with conflicting interests, challenges established assumptions and safeguards the quality of advice across the organisation.
integrity and dependability Acting in line with applicable standards and agreements, also without supervision, and being transparent about own interests, mistakes and doubtful cases.	Keeps to agreements and rules of conduct made and reports an own mistake to the manager.	Reports a possible conflict of interest on own initiative and asks for review before a decision is taken.	Sets the organisation's integrity standards, enforces them also with influential parties and explains the resulting choices publicly.
Applying legislation Applies laws, decrees and policy rules to individual cases, weighs exceptions and records the reasoning behind the decision.	Applies the fixed decision rules to a standard case and refers doubtful cases to an experienced case handler.	Independently assesses an application with exceptional circumstances, weighs discretionary room and motivates the decision traceably.	Sets policy rules and work instructions for implementation and decides on application questions that set precedent.
Verbal reasoning Understands written and spoken language and draws logical conclusions from it, also when the text is long, dense or ambiguous.	Summarises a short work instruction in own words and points out which word or sentence remains unclear.	Extracts the core arguments from a report of several pages and shows with textual references which conclusion does and does not follow.	Dissects legal or policy texts with conflicting passages, reformulates the central question and substantiates the chosen reading for the whole organisation.
Judgement under uncertainty Weighs the possible explanations when data are missing or conflicting and reaches a reasoned judgement while stating the remaining uncertainty.	Indicates which data are missing when in doubt and proposes a provisional judgement to the manager.	Forms a judgement on incomplete files, names the assumptions used and states which new fact would change that judgement.	Judges in situations of high uncertainty and opposing interests, accounts for this publicly and revises the judgement on new evidence.
Stakeholder management Mapping who has an interest in an initiative and maintaining contact with those parties so that decisions keep their support.	Maintains a list of those involved and informs them about progress according to the agreed rhythm.	Assesses influence and interest per party, chooses a fitting form of contact and discusses conflicting wishes before a decision is taken.	Maintains a network reaching governance and political bodies, connects parties with differing interests and safeguards the position of the organisation.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
organisational awareness Recognising how formal and informal relations, interests and decision making work in the organisation and taking these into account in own actions.	Asks who needs to be involved in a topic before a proposal is shared with others.	Assesses which interests a proposal touches, involves the right people beforehand and chooses a suitable moment to raise it.	Sees through relations between organisational units and external parties and steers decision making by organising support at an early stage.
Policy development Develops policy through problem analysis, exploration of options, consultation of stakeholders and elaboration into goals, instruments and evaluation.	Collects figures and documents for a policy exploration under guidance and summarises the findings briefly.	Independently elaborates a policy proposal with options and expected effects and organises consultation of the parties involved.	Sets the policy course for a domain, connects parties in the chain and has the effects evaluated systematically.
Systems thinking Describes how parts of a process or organisation influence each other, including feedback, delay and unintended effects.	Names who or what depends on the own task earlier and later in the process.	Maps the chain around a bottleneck, points out the feedback loop and predicts the effect of an intervention.	Models the interplay between departments, market and regulation and shifts the intervention to the point with the greatest leverage.
Editing and plain language Shortening, reordering and rewriting existing texts in plainer language without losing content, nuance or legal meaning.	Removes redundant words and repetitions from a text and corrects spelling according to a given checklist.	Rewrites a formal letter to plain language level B1 and explains to the author which choices were made.	Introduces an organisation wide plain language approach, measures readability of core products and adjusts standards based on user testing.
Negotiating Reaching an agreement with one or more parties by exploring interests, using trade offs and consciously holding agreed limits.	Negotiates delivery time or price within fixed margins and refers any deviation to the manager.	Prepares a range and a fallback option beforehand, trades points of unequal weight and closes with written confirmation.	Leads negotiations on multi year contracts or employment terms, sets the mandate and defines the negotiating line for the organisation.
independence Forming and maintaining an own position on the basis of own judgement, even when the environment or an authority expects something different.	Forms an own opinion on a familiar issue and compares it with the advice of a colleague.	Takes a decision that departs from the group line, explains the reasoning behind it and accepts the consequences.	Protects own professional judgement against pressure from stakeholders in senior forums and makes dissenting positions traceable and explainable.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
Professional currency and specialist literature Follows developments in the own profession through literature, guidelines and networks and works relevant new insights into own practice.	Reads the professional information received and names which part matters for the own work.	Tracks sources and guidelines structurally, weighs their quality and adapts the own working method to new insights.	Assesses the state of the field, weighs conflicting research and determines which guidelines the organisation will follow from now on.
Searching and evaluating digital information Searches digital information with suitable search strategies, judges source and currency and records where information was found traceably.	Searches with given search terms in the designated sources and reports what was and was not found.	Combines search terms and filters across several sources, weighs source reliability and justifies the selection made.	Develops search and evaluation standards for the profession and trains others in weighing digital sources.
GDPR and privacy in practice Knows privacy legislation requirements for own work, which legal basis and retention period apply and recognises when notification is required.	Processes personal data only according to the applicable work instruction and refers doubtful cases to the privacy officer.	Judges in own processes whether a legal basis exists, applies data minimisation and handles requests from data subjects correctly.	Sets privacy policy, decides on high risk processing operations and represents the organisation towards the supervisory authority.
Contracting and closing Converts a verbal agreement into a valid offer and contract, clears remaining objections and gets the customer to sign.	Fills in a standard agreement with the agreed details and checks whether all annexes are present.	Recognises buying signals, names the remaining objection and puts a signable proposal on the table within own authority.	Designs the contract forms and mandates for the organisation and decides on exceptions in deals with major financial impact.
Basic contract law knowledge Knows the main rules on offer, acceptance, breach of contract and general terms and recognises when legal advice is needed.	Uses the standard agreement of the organisation and refers deviating clauses to a legal adviser.	Assesses contracts on liability, termination and payment and proposes amendments within the own mandate.	Sets the contract templates and legal frameworks of the organisation and decides on deviations with major risk.
Complying with sector regulation Knows the laws, standards and supervisory requirements of the own sector and organises the own work and records accordingly.	Works according to the applicable sector rules and checks which rule applies to a new situation.	Translates changed regulation into the own work instructions and checks whether the records meet the requirements.	Tracks regulation for the whole organisation, drafts policy when requirements change and holds the dialogue with the supervisor.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
Public governance decision making Prepares decisions for a board or council with memoranda, options and consultation, taking political, legal and financial frameworks into account.	Drafts a memorandum under guidance in the standard format and collects the annexes the file requires.	Independently prepares a decision with clear options, aligns with the departments involved and anticipates questions from the council.	Determines the governance agenda and the quality requirements for decision making and advises officeholders on politically sensitive files.
Stress tolerance Keeps delivering work of the same quality under time pressure, opposition or unexpected turns and maintains a businesslike tone with others.	Keeps working on the current task as pressure rises and asks the supervisor which task can wait.	Keeps working in a structured way at peak load, keeps agreements with clients clear and flags early which results are at risk.	Keeps the organisation workable in crises, takes decisions under high uncertainty and sets the standard for composed action under pressure.
Handling objections and appeals Handles objections and appeals, hears interested parties, reviews the contested decision and drafts a reasoned ruling.	Registers an objection, checks the deadlines and drafts the standard letters to interested parties.	Independently chairs a hearing, weighs the grounds put forward and writes a ruling a court can follow.	Designs the organisation's objection procedure, analyses rulings and steers towards fewer upheld objections.
Planning own work Translates own work into a plan with steps, interim results and lead times, and tracks progress against that plan throughout the period.	Fills in a pre structured weekly schedule and discusses with the supervisor which step to take first.	Builds an own plan with milestones and dependencies, checks progress weekly and revises the plan when actual progress deviates.	Introduces planning methods that are adopted across the discipline and decides how capacity is distributed over multi year work streams.

6 Assessment methods and validity

The validities are the corrected meta-analytic estimates from Sackett, Zhang, Berry and Lievens (2022) in the Journal of Applied Psychology, which replace the older Schmidt and Hunter (1998) figures. The spread matters as much as the mean: with a high SD, validity varies strongly by context.

Assessment method	rho	SD	What it is
Werkproef	0.33	0.09	The candidate performs a representative work sample under standardised conditions.
Assessment center	0.29	0.09	Multiple exercises, multiple assessors, dimension-wise scoring.
Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	0.40	0.15	Self-report of behavioural preferences. At hrnforce the Big Fifty and the 15PF.
Kennistoets	0.40	0.13	Test of declarative job knowledge, usually assembled per client.
Cognitieve capaciteitentest	0.41	0.14	Standardised test of verbal, numerical or abstract reasoning.
Situational Judgement Test	0.12	0.11	Scenario with response options, scored on knowledge or behavioural tendency.
Portfolio/bewijsstuk	-	-	A collection of prior work or results, assessed against fixed criteria.

7 Assessment instruments for this job

hrnforce instrument	Skills	What it measures
Competency Check	12	Competentiebeoordeling op gedragsniveau
Werkproef	8	Representatief werkfragment onder gestandaardiseerde condities
Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)	7	Toets van vakkennis, per klant samengesteld
360 Feedback	4	Meervoudige beoordeling op gedragsankers
Big Fifty	4	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst, 150 items, 25 factoren
Portfolio	3	Beoordeling van eerder werk tegen vaste criteria
Structureerd interview	2	Gedragsgericht interview met vaste opzet
Ability Scan	2	Capaciteitentest: verbaal, numeriek en abstract redeneervermogen
15PF	2	Persoonlijkheidsprofiel, korter alternatief voor de Big Fifty
Big Fifty (schaal Integriteit)	1	
Conflictstijlen	1	Voorkeursstijl in conflictsituaties

hrmforce instrument	Skills	What it measures
Mentale Weerbaarheid (4C)	1	Mentale weerbaarheid volgens het 4C-model

8 How to use this profile

1. Agree the profile with the hiring manager before the first candidate is measured. Weights shifted afterwards make the outcome indefensible.
2. Choose the assessment method per skill from the Assessment method column. Combine at most three methods per candidate.
3. Calibrate the assessors in a two-hour session using the anchors in chapter 5. Anchors without rater training deliver little.
4. Fill in the match calculator and discuss the gaps in the development conversation. Type A and type G are selection criteria, not one-quarter development goals.

Source: hrmforce Skills Framework 2.0, version 2.0.0, built 2026-09-08. Crosswalks to ESCO v1.2.1, O*NET 31.0, Lightcast Open Skills, SFIA 9, DigComp 3.0, EntreComp, LifeComp, GreenComp, AILit, WEF Future of Jobs 2025, ISCO-08 and the Dutch CBS occupational classification BRC 2014 edition 2025. This profile is a starting point, not a standard: align it with your own organisation before selecting on it.